

DESPAIR AND HOPE
A clogged stormwater drain in Adugodi in central Bengaluru; (right) Narasimhan with the restored K-100 drain

if he could identify even 1 kilometre of Bengaluru's 11,000 kilometres of roads that did not have a pothole. Bommai promised a thorough audit of the roads. In 2019, the TomTom Traffic Index, which evaluates traffic services across the globe, rated Bengaluru as the world's worst city in terms of traffic congestion, with people spending an extra 243 hours that year commuting.

Housing its burgeoning millions is another major worry. The boom saw an explosion of largely unplanned vertical and horizontal residential colonies. Rents too are soaring, with a two-bedroom house in Indiranagar now fetching Rs 1 lakh at the higher end, double of what it commanded prior to the pandemic. In addition, more than 400 slums have come up in random fashion, and they house almost a third of the city's population. The total housing shortage is estimated to touch 2.56 million by 2031, with the economically weaker sections bearing the brunt of this crisis. A recent study based on 500 workers in Bengaluru found they lived in shared spaces, half of which were no more than covered sheds, and shared toilets or used public facilities.

Yet, amazingly, the Union ministry of housing and urban affairs (MoHUA) ranked Bengaluru as No. 1 among 49 cities with a million-plus population in its Ease of Living Index (EoLI) for 2020. Attribute it to Bengaluru's consistently high score in terms of economic prowess. However, cut to municipal performance and sustainability development, and the city ranked 31 out of 51 cities in the MoHUA's Municipal Performance Index (MIP) for the same year, faring poorly in key criteria such as services, technology, finance, urban planning and governance. NITI Aayog's first Sustainable Development Index released in 2021 confirmed the trend: while Bengaluru was a frontrunner in providing jobs and ensuring economic growth, it stood 13th on sustainability issues.

FIVE REASONS THE CITY IS GOING TO SEED

What explains Bengaluru's descent into chaos and decrepitude? The blame for the city's boom and subsequent bust is wrongly pinned on its crown jewel, the IT or information technology sector. Tech czar N.R. Narayana Murthy, the founding chairman of Infosys, recalls the time he first visited Bengaluru in the early 1960s to see his sister. Forget vehicles, even humans were hard to find on its roads. By the mid-1980s, when Murthy shifted his nascent company from Pune to Bengaluru, the city had already undergone a radical transformation. It was a boom city long before Murthy and a dozen other pioneers spawned the IT miracle.

The first wave of the city's growth came in the 1960s when public sector giants like HMT, BEL, ITI and BEML were set up to capitalise on Bengaluru's clean air as well as its scientific and technological base. Then, with surplus power, the city's planners threw open its doors to businesses from across the country in the Seventies. With industrialists in Bombay beset with union troubles and those in Calcutta harassed by the Naxal movement, they moved to Bangalore in droves. By 1983, when INDIA TODAY featured a cover story chronicling Bangalore's boom, it was already among the fastest growing cities in the world. The entry of the IT sector at the turn of the century only accelerated that growth. The prosperity, though, came at a price, as the city's infrastructure began heading for a total breakdown. If Bengaluru has become a textbook case for how to ruin a city, there are five major reasons other Indian metros and wannabe cities can learn from and avoid.

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